Once the Kočevje Germans had left, their villages were largely destroyed by the Italian army to prevent them from being used by the Communist resistance movement that had headquarters in the woods in the area. What remained of the houses and churches of Kočevje Germans after the Italians were gone was then finally destroyed by the Communist authorities after the war, clearing the area of any memory of the community including, above all, its religious monuments. Moreover, this battered-down area also became the killing fields for Slovenian and other Yugoslav anti-Communist troops after the war. Finally, it was turned into an off-limits area, where only hunting havens and nuclear-proof shelters for the Slovenian political elite were allowed to exist. The Kočevje Germans were not mentioned again until after 1990 (and nor were the massacres of anti-Communists). Only then was it possible to state that Slovenia was poorer without a community that by that time had been long scattered around the globe. It was too late: another precious link between Eastern Europe and ethnic Germans had been destroyed. Now the local museum dedicated to their memory and the books published about them stand in place of their overgrown villages, lost amidst the dense forests that surround them.

If that sounds nostalgic to some it is perhaps because people in Eastern Europe who can still see some merits in the old Austrian Empire, despite all its faults, are also today at great risk of being seen as naïve. The unspeakable suffering caused to Slav nations by the Nazis (including many Austrians) erased most of the good memories of the times of earlier Habsburg rule. Any claim today that a more restrained German nationalism and a decision to make Austria-Hungary a federal state with strong autonomy for the Slavic nations would have saved it and perhaps would have created a European model-state, is easily dismissed as pure and naive speculation. The world of Central Europe as it existed for several centuries is said to be finally lost in the ashes of World War II. Even the German language, which was the *lingua franca* of Central Europe for centuries, was replaced by English (as with Russian in Central Europe), a language that belongs to modern times and to the wider world but not to the region. Not only that: the general public both in German-speaking and Slavic countries has today almost completely lost its awareness of a shared history and of being a part of the same Central European culture. History, as taught under Communism, assisted greatly in this process: not only did we learn to